and I'm floating (in a most peculiar way)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34691845.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Razz (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
SPOP Creative Flex (She-Ra), Alternate Universe - Future, Angst, Angst with a Happy Ending, this fic is 90 percent angst, You've been warned, Outer Space, Space Flight, Space Stations, space and time have an interesting relationship, friends to lovers to exes to millions of miles away to ??, possible emotional damage, the following tags are for part 2, Minor Character Death, Grieving, Hurt/Comfort, Remembering How to Love, they have a lot to talk about, It Gets Worse Before It Gets Better, Fluff

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English

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Part 5 of Iorek's Catradora AUs

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by IorekoftheHorde

Summary

Slowly but surely, Catra became what her friends called a "space-nerd", but she wasn't ashamed of the title. Space was her first love, and her second—

"What are you reading?"

—was that blonde goof who one day, entirely unprompted, sat opposite her in Razz's diner and asked her what she was reading.

Notes

Written as part of the September SPOP Creative Flex art prompt drawn by the amazing EmileeDoodles! (which you can find **here!**)

The main art piece features 4 frames from Catra and Adora's life. For some reason, when I saw them, my brain thought: but what if we add Space to this too?
So here we are.

As mentioned in the tags, this fic is 90% angst. You have officially been warned. Twice.

(Thank you to Emilee and Zoey for beta-reading!)

See the end of the work for more notes

Catra, 1 Year after the Serenia 2's launch

Catra was young when she first met Adora. Early teens, she thinks. It was probably just another day to Adora, but for Catra it changed everything. Part of her hopes it was the same for Adora too, but she feels guilty for hoping that. She ruined it, after all. Everything they built together, all the promises and plans they made for their future. She ruined it. Burnt it to the ground.

Even so, the day Catra first met Adora still comes to her. She thinks about it, sometimes, wondering what her life would have been like if she'd never met the blonde goof in the first place. The thought of never meeting Adora kind of makes her want to cry.

Catra closes her eyes. She can't cry. Not unless she wants to deal with her tears spreading over her face or just floating aimlessly in front of her. Plus, her crewmates would get worried, and she can't have them distracted, not when they're almost at their first stop of their five year voyage (eight years for everyone back home, Space is weird about time like that). Catra instead focuses on the memory of meeting Adora for the first time, how the other girl made her feel so free, so alive, like she could do anything.

Adora, Catra would later learn, was a few months younger than her. But that didn't seem to matter in the grand scheme of things, as Adora was always a little taller, her hands a little bigger, her shoulders a little wider. She was perfect. When Catra spotted her across the park, Catra thought she was perfect. The perfect height and size for Catra to sit on her shoulders so she could get her cat down from the tree they'd run up again after escaping through the front door while her mums brought the shopping in. Catra had immediately taken off after Melog, dropping to all fours to keep up, her tail whipping around like crazy in the wind. She followed her family's cat to the park, watched as it climbed a tree, scoffed when she realised it got itself stuck.

But her smile soon faded when she realised she'd done the exact same thing three times when she was littler, needing her mums to rescue her. Catra wasn't tall enough to reach the branch, and she certainly didn't trust herself to *climb* the tree, so when she saw a big blonde girl around her age across the park, she didn't hesitate to call out to her.

Adora was very understanding, eagerly offering her assistance to help Catra with her little predicament.

Which is how Catra ended up on Adora's shoulders, Melog in hand, being carried back towards her house.

As soon as Catra got her hands on Melog, she realised she couldn't let go of them without the possibility of them running off again. The last time they successfully ran away, they were gone for a week, and Catra was beyond distraught that her cuddle buddy had abandoned her. This time, she wouldn't let them get away, but that also meant she couldn't get down from Adora's shoulders. Adora, because she was always a dumbass, just offered to walk her back home. A dumbass, yes, but a sweet one. Catra was charmed immediately, and the feeling of Adora's hands around her calves holding her in place only got more distracting the longer they remained.

Her mums were confused, at first, thinking that maybe Catra had managed to hurt herself. Catra didn't get a chance to explain though, as Adora just immediately burst into an energetic explanation of how they'd worked together to rescue Melog from the low branch of a tree in the park.

Catra's eyes snap open as she's pulled from her thoughts and memories by a buzzing and a sharp beep; one of the stasis pods nearby finishing it's wake-up cycle for the occupant inside. Catra remembers getting in hers first, so it makes sense that she'd be the first to wake up too, since they were all set for the same amount of time. But, as she watches Scorpia float out of her pod and into the centre of the circular chamber, Catra's grateful for the

few moments of peace she had to remember the only thing that made her happy. The only person. The only warmth.

Scorpia seems confused when she sees that Catra hasn't moved yet, like there might be something wrong with her, like the wake-up cycle or the stasis might have gone wrong somehow for Catra to be immobile. Catra decides to offer her crewmate a small smile and a wave to allay any of those possibilities, however, and relaxes a little when Scorpia's expression softens.

'Have you looked outside yet?' Is the first thing Scorpia asks, since the silent "are you okay" was answered already. Catra just shakes her head, watching as Scorpia's face lights up. 'Do you mind if I–?'

Catra smiles again, resting her head back against the padding of her pod as her body tries to float out of it, held back by the buckles around her waist and thighs. 'No, Scorp, go ahead.'

Scorpia beams, turning to float away further into their shuttle to find a viewport. The question of who would get to be the first to see a new planet with their own eyes was one Catra didn't really care for. Any planet without Adora on it was one she kind of never wanted to visit. Not anymore. But that's their mission, so she has to. Besides, it's not like Adora will be waiting for her when she returns anyway. Catra made it perfectly clear that she didn't want that. But, now, deep in the far reaches of space on a voyage to explore a number of new worlds that could hold life, all she can think is that she made an awful mistake.

Catra regrets pushing Adora away, even though she still believes it was the best thing for them. The best thing for *Adora* . It would be better this way. Adora could move on with her life, forget about Catra, live for something other than their stupid dreams and plans for how they thought their lives would go. It's better this way. Catra can exist out here, isolated with just two others, yearning for everything she'll never have when she returns to Etheria, and Adora can be free to finally *live* .

———————

When they're finally on approach to this new world, which looks similar to Etheria apart from the bright pink oceans, the crew of the Serenia 2 strap themselves down into actual chairs that unfold up from what will become the floor once gravity steps in to tell them how things should be. Entrapta, their technical specialist, woke up a couple of minutes after Scorpia and immediately flung herself through the craft, running all kinds of tests Catra didn't have the training to understand. That wasn't her job, after all. Catra was the pilot and biologist.

Pilot, because it was up to her to land them safely on each new planet as well as take off again, efficiently enough that they would use as little fuel as possible. That's what they told her, what she trained for, but Catra knew they just wanted her to take it easy when they left any particularly grabby atmospheres. Punching through them would eat up their fuel reserves, whereas coasting through Space required very little thrust at all to get them moving.

Her second title was Biologist because it was up to her to choose which things they needed samples of. She was aware that biologist was just a fancy name for "oooh, this looks cool, we'll take some of it for someone else to look at again later, but *closer* ", as all of the actual analysis would happen back on Etheria once they return, but it sounded better than *plant magpie* .

Catra extended the yoke from the panel in front of her, preparing herself to take over from the autopilot she set before entering her stasis pod… a year ago? It didn't feel like a year. It felt like she went to sleep and woke up again a few hours later, but that's Dryl bio-engineering for you. Although, Catra's starting to believe that Entrapta may have actually *built* the shuttle they're in, because she keeps calling it *Darla* instead of it's actual callsign, and seems

to know where everything is, even deep within the walls of circuitry, as if she *put it there* . No doubt that kind of thing would be kept classified, however, sending up the designer of a ship in the ship they designed. But with the way Entrapta caresses the levers and buttons, rather than pressing or pulling them as one would normally, Catra believes that they couldn't stop Entrapta from coming on the voyage if they tried.

Scorpia is practically buzzing with excitement, barely able to keep herself still as she fidgets in place. Catra isn't particularly sure what Scorpia's briefing is for this trip but, judging by her large, strong-looking pincers and kind-of-intimidating stinger, she imagines that Scorpia may be their unofficial bodyguard and muscle. Of course, Catra could just *ask* Scorpia what her role is on the Serenia 2, they've got plenty of time until they're anywhere close to landing (pre-landing safety means they have to be strapped down far in advance) and a conversation would fill the time perfectly, but Catra's worried that she's *already* supposed to know. She remembers being given a file on her crewmates skills and jobs and shit, but she can't remember reading them, per se, and she realises she only knows Entrapta's skills and tasks because she never shuts up about them.

Instead of talking to her crewmates, however, Catra leans back in her chair as the Serenia's blast shields extend to cover the cockpit's reinforced windscreen, protecting them against the possible heat and light of atmospheric entry. She closes her eyes, making sure to keep her ears attuned to any warning signals, and works on calming herself down. This is *it* , after all, the first stop of many along their plotted route. If this one goes well, Catra has no doubt she can pull off all the landings and launches without issue.

"You would be an amazing astronaut!" Are the words that Catra hears floating to the surface of her memories, *"I don't think I could ever do that, it seems scary."*

"You're so dumb, Adora, Space isn't scary."

"Sure it is! It's all dark and there's nothing there. It's like the ocean."

"Okay, you're wrong on so many levels. Have you ever actually looked at the sky at night? Or seen any of those ocean documentaries? The ocean is full of life, and I know that Space is too. It's not dark, and there's way more than nothing out there, it's just spread out really far."

"How do you know?"

"I just do. I'm going up there, aren't I? I'll prove it to you. I'll prove that out there in Space, there's everything *."*

Catra smiles at the memory, it was maybe a week or two after Adora helped her get Melog down from that tree branch. She'd finished school for the day and, like she always did, stopped to get a milkshake on her way home. Her mums' were usually home a little later than Catra finished school, and they knew the owner of the nearest diner, so a deal was struck in which Catra would get a little extra pocket money each week to buy herself something there before heading home and Razz would watch over her. Catra would never tell her mums this, but Razz never once let her pay.

Razz, Catra would quickly discover, was an old astronaut, one of the first, and was filled to the brim with stories of how she explored each of Etheria's moons one by one, discovering something new each time. Sometimes it was entire plants, or new insects, but sometimes it was just the composition of the soil, the rock, the air (or lack of it). Whatever it was, Razz made it sound like the biggest adventure there is, and Catra was completely star-struck. She started asking for books on space, little scale models of rockets, even bouncy balls that looked like plants. Catra even built her own orrery of Etheria that showed the correct orbit of each of its twelve moons.

Slowly but surely, Catra became what her friends called a "space-nerd", but she wasn't ashamed of the title. Space was her first love, and her second—

"What are you reading?"

—was that blonde goof who one day, entirely unprompted, sat opposite her in Razz's diner and asked her what she was reading.

"A book about all the discoveries made on Elidor since we first started going there."

"Oh, cool," Catra watched as Adora's face remained blank, staring the other girl down until, *"What's Elidor?"*

Catra laughed at how apologetic the question sounded, but also how the answer should really be common knowledge, *"It's one of Etheria's moons, dummy, how do you not know that?"*

Adora spluttered for a moment, her cheeks a little red at being caught out, *"I totally knew that! I was just testing you!"*

"Uhuh. And the fact that my book is titled Secrets of Elidor *with a photo of Elidor on the cover wasn't a big enough hint?"*

"Well I didn't… okay, you got me. Why don't you tell me about it?"

"No, that's okay. It's dumb, you'd probably find it boring."

Catra would never forget the way Adora's lit up as she said, *"It's not dumb! You like it, so it must be cool! I want to hear all about it!"* Nor would she forget the way her chest tightened as her first proper crush unknowingly wiggled its way into her heart.

"If you beat me in a milkshake drinking contest, I'll tell you everything!"

"Deal!"

And that's how Catra conned Adora into getting a brain freeze. She did keep up her end of the bargain, however. Adora started going round to her house and Catra would show her all of her Space stuff. All her models, all her books, all her drawings. Catra

was starstruck with the way Adora soaked everything in, the way she listened to every word Catra spoke.

Looking back, it was kind of inevitable that Catra would end up falling in love with her.

Beep Beep Beep Beep Beep Beep Be—

Catra shut off the alarm signalling an increase in turbulence, it was entirely unnecessary; she could feel it, *hear* it. They'd started to enter the planet's upper atmosphere, and the Serenia was handling it like a champ. Behind her, Catra hears Entrapta squealing and giggling as if she's on some kind of funfair ride. Scorpia sounds more reserved, nervous, her exoskeleton clacking as she taps against her tail to try to calm herself down.

'Scorpia,' Catra calls back over her shoulder and, when she hears the clacking stop, she continues, 'I've got this.Trust me.'

'I do. I trust you, Wildcat,' came Scorpia's response, and Catra smiles.

After the blast shield finally descends back into the ship, and the crew of the Serenia see another planet's surface up close for the first time, they all stare in awe. Catra can see all kinds of vibrant colours down below, forests of green and purple. The oceans, a vibrant pink. The mountains, capped with the familiar sight of white snow. It's breathtaking. It's everything she used to dream it would be.

But it isn't everything she dreams about now.

Catra disables the autopilot, allowing the yoke to come to life in her hands as she begins steering them towards a viable landing sight, 'I have control.'

'You have control,' her crewmates confirm behind her.

Catra takes a deep breath. This is it, finally, everything she's dreamed of since she was little. Only, little Catra didn't plan for

what she'd have to leave behind to get it, and astronaut Catra's heart aches to get back to that warmth, that safety, that blanket of love—

—that she broke up with.

Why did she have to go and push it away?

Adora, 3 Years after the Serenia 2's launch

Looking back, Adora knows she didn't mean to fall in love with her best friend.

She just sort of *did* .

It was slow, a gradual build up of emotion that she didn't realise was consuming her until Catra kissed her the first time. The fall was slow, but it was *beautiful* . Adora wouldn't change it for anything. Those years she spent with Catra were the happiest Adora's ever been, and she looks back on them fondly, despite the ache in her chest, the hollow space where Catra used to be.

No, Catra's still there. Adora knows she will always be there because Catra, over the years, carved out her own special place in Adora's heart. And, even though Catra herself left Adora behind, it gives Adora some relief to know that she was part of Catra's life, she was important, she mattered to someone.

Until she didn't anymore.

Sometimes, even though she shouldn't, Adora takes a moment to stop what she's doing—be it repairing the meteor paneling on Arxia Station's main hull, installing even more solar panels, or rerouting power manually from the outside of the station because another engineer on the inside overloaded the auxiliary power circuits—she stops, putting her full faith into her mag-boots, and stands up on the outside of Arxia station, and she *looks* .

Adora looks out into the vastness of Space. Hoping, longing, *waiting* .

Catra's out there, somewhere, doing what she always dreamed of. Exploring new worlds, finding new life, experiencing true adventure for the first time. Just like they always used to talk about when Adora would sleep over at Catra's house. The two of them, whispering and giggling while making up stories about what they would get up to on another planet.

Adora's first mistake was underestimating how serious Catra really was about everything she said.

Her second mistake was failing as her girlfriend.

Catra kissed Adora the summer they finished school, before they started at the same college together. Catra told her how much she meant to her, how she never thought someone could mean so much to another person. Catra bared herself for Adora to see, and Adora accepted her with open arms and a warm embrace.

Adora, in return, told Catra how she'd always been drawn to her, even if she didn't realise why at first. Adora recalled how her friends would tease her about her crush endlessly whenever they saw her with Catra, and how she'd planned this huge day out where she would tell her how she felt about her. Adora told Catra that she'd loved her since the day they met, and knew that she would never stop loving her as long as she lived.

They were brilliant together, vibrant, happy. Adora remembers those years in college, spent beside the girl she loves, with a

fondness that never fails to warm her heart. She thinks it was the happiest time of her life, getting to be with Catra, allowed to love her the way she deserved. To spoil her rotten with presents and kisses. Catra soaked it up, too, and returned the affection in kind.

But then they graduated, and soon after Catra broke the news to Adora that she wouldn't be going to the university they'd planned on going on attending together. Apparently, Catra had applied to train to be an astronaut and been accepted. After all, she was physically fit, smart, and already had a wondrous knowledge of Space. She didn't think she'd actually get in, so she hadn't really told anyone when she made the application. Adora was the first person she told, eyes wide with excitement and wonder. Adora saw the worry, the fear, and the nerves there too, and knew she had to go along with it.

So, with Adora's full support, Catra moved out of her mothers' house in Bright Moon to go live in Dryl, the base of operations for Etheria's space program.

At first, everything went smoothly. For the first two years of Catra's training, Catra and Adora would call and text each other almost daily, and Adora would travel to see her as often as she could.

"What's it like?" Adora asked the first time she visited, holding hands with Catra across the table at a small Cafe in Dryl. Adora had met up with Catra within the city itself, having to wait while her girlfriend caught the one bus that travels to and from the facility only twice a day. They had the whole day to spend together, until Catra would need to catch it again to go back. Adora had asked if she could go, but Catra just laughed and said they wouldn't let her if she tried.

Adora was already getting sick of the words classified, confidential, restricted, and top secret.

"It's amazing," was Catra's sincere response. She looked so excited, so full of energy, practically buzzing with anticipation of

what it was she would be doing. *"It's mostly been intro stuff so far, showing us round and some quick tests to 'establish our current skill-set' or something. But we start training properly next week. They said that not everyone will make it all the way through, like if anyone gets injured or can't handle the tests, but I'm pretty confident I can do it."*

"Of course you can do it, Catra," Adora said, her voice soft and words sincere, *"It's you. You're amazing. You can do anything."*

Adora remembers the way Catra's tail curled around her leg under the table, the way her claws dug into her hands just a little, the way her pupils dilated and the way her ears swivelled round to focus in on the girl opposite her. Adora remembers the way Catra stood up, how she leant across the table to kiss her there and then, long and slow. It was everything.

"Ahem."

Catra shot backwards immediately, her face burning, and Adora couldn't help but laugh a little at getting caught up in her girlfriend in such a public place. Luckily, Catra wasn't too bothered either, smiling back at Adora through her embarrassment.

Their waiter just continued, undeterred, *"One extra large strawberry milkshake supreme, with extra…"* he squinted down at the receipt in his hand, *"everything, it seems. And two straws and two spoons. Here you are."* He set everything down carefully and wordlessly left soon after when it was clear he was already forgotten. Catra pounced on the milkshake immediately, picking off all the sprinkles she liked best with the tips of her claws, and Adora just watched with a sad smile on her face, wondering when she'd get to see her again.

'Adora!' The crackling of one of her best-friend's voices filling her helmet shook Adora from her thoughts, and she glanced up at the form steadily approaching where she was still planted to the side of the space station, 'Are you okay?'

‘I’m fine, Bow,’ Adora answered easily. It *was* the easy answer, after all, ‘Just thinking.’

Bow’s laugh was always contagious, and Adora couldn’t hold down her smile for long, ‘Well don’t stand out here too long, breathing is a thing, remember? What are your levels?’

Ah, right. Yes. Adora, not for the first time, had forgotten that she was hooked up to a finite oxygen supply. ‘Uh,’ Adora winced when she checked, knowing that she was already too low to just be standing there, ‘fifteen.’

‘Fifteen?!’ Bow had managed to get much closer, close enough that Adora could see his mouth moving through his helmet. ‘Well let's get you inside. I’m at thirty, so if you need topping up let me know. It’s ten back to the hatch.’

Adora nodded, glancing over her shoulder in the direction they needed to go before grabbing the drill that was still floating in front of her, where she’d left it. ‘Okay, let me just grab my things.’

The only thing holding Adora in place and stopping her from floating off into that infinite void—" *not* a void. So *full* of life, of possibilities," as Catra would say—was the pair of industrial magnets built into the boots of her suit that, to be able to walk with them, she has to turn on and off with buttons on her gloves, built into the thumb side of each of the index fingers. This meant that the tool case she had with her, just large enough to fit the necessities inside, had to clip onto a cord looped around her body so that it would move as she did and leave her hands free to operate the mag-boots.

By the time Bow reached Adora, she was ready to head back to the airlock, and the two of them steadily made their way back to the relative safety of the interior of Arxia station, one magnetised step at a time.

———————

If Bow noticed that Adora's oxygen tank was only 2% away from being empty when they sealed the airlock and began taking their suits off, he didn't say anything. Not *immediately* , anyway. But even if he was planning on bringing it up again later, Adora was grateful for the brief reprieve from dealing with it right that moment. They changed in near silence, except to coordinate helping each other out of their protective equipment, and soon Adora was following Bow toward the first ring of Arxia station.

Arxia's first ring was the foundation on which the rest of the station was built up from. There are five rings in total now, but the first has a little bit of everything. Adora's most visited areas would have to be the fully equipped gym, the simple yet sizable farm and herb garden, as well as the basic cafeteria that used to be the hub of activity on the station, back when there were less rings. Ever since the powers that be signed some kind of deal with a popular coffee chain back on Etheria upon the completion of the fourth ring, however, the majority of the crew spend their time there instead. Everyone except the Best Friend Squad, that is.

Adora met Bow and his then girlfriend, now fiancee, Glimmer, when she first arrived at the Dryl training facility for the Etherian Space Program. Adora remembers being reluctant, at first, stepping foot in the place where Catra also trained, but meeting those bundles of happiness and joy made the entire thing much easier.

They had already been there a year or so already, so were able to help Adora adjust to life there fairly seamlessly. She opened up to them quickly, it seemed easier, telling them about her life with Catra up until how she heard about the chance to work on a space station.

After graduating with her degree in Sport and Exercise Therapy, Adora worked as a personal trainer and physical therapist for about a year before she saw the announcement that Etheria would be sending a series of rockets to build a manned station in

a carefully calculated orbit around Etheria that would ensure it was far enough away from any of the 12 moons. The media called it *"Etheria's Thirteenth Moon!"* which is, honestly, kind of appropriate, considering it's definitely larger than at least two of Etheria's actual moons. Adora remembers Catra explaining once how some people thought that they shouldn't be referred to as moons because they were too small, but the idea never caught on and to this day Etheria still has 12 moons.

Adora told them everything, more than she told anyone else. She didn't have any family to tell, after all, and she refused to burden Catra's mothers with her problems alongside their daughter leaving for eight years.

When they reach the cafeteria of the first ring, Bow leading with Adora following behind, Glimmer is already there and seated at their usual table. It's the one farthest from the kitchen, but also situated right next to a wide viewport.

Bow leans down to kiss her when they get to the table, then sits down beside her as Adora seats herself opposite, staring out of the viewport and into Space.

'Do you think it's Catra again?' Glimmer attempts to whisper to Bow, accidentally loud enough that Adora can hear her, but she doesn't mind. She knows her friends are only trying to look out for her, and they already know all about Catra anyway.

Bow nods in response, Adora can see him reflected in the window, 'I think so,' he replies, not being too careful about masking his voice. He knows Adora heard them, but unlike Glimmer he's just that little bit more attentive to people and their feelings. Maybe he should have been a therapist instead of some kind of electrical engineer.

'Adora…' Glimmer starts slowly, choosing her words carefully, 'you have to stop endangering yourself like that. What if Bow hadn't contacted you when he did? Would you have just stared off into Space until you ran out of air?'

Adora's jaw clenches and she feels her hands forming fists under the table. She *knows.* She knows that she's not supposed to look off into Space while they're working, but it's like she *needs* to look. Because, if she doesn't… well, she doesn't really know. All Adora knows is that out there: that's where Catra is. Adora's everything. Adora just wants her to be okay, to come back safe.

Before Adora has a chance to find her words, Glimmer's already continuing, grilling her about work practices as well as the upcoming large-scale project that ground control has lined up for them.

'We have to be ready and on our A game,' Glimmer says, tapping her fingers on the table, 'They'll be ready to send up the expansion modules for Arxia within the month. We have to be ready and in full working order to receive them. Don't forget that this is all in preparation for the moon colonisation project. Etheria's orbit is about to get a lot busier, and we… *I* need you focused. Everything will be going through us.'

Adora *knows* all that. She read the reports three times, thinking about how much Catra would absolutely adore the sound of it. The dream, as Dryl phrased it, is to turn the Arxia space station into a kind of hub for transport to and from Etheria and its moons. It sounds amazing. People living and working on the Moons, with a means of easily getting back down to the surface through Arxia. Of course, the first people there will be those building the habs, the places for people to live, as well as leaving behind the supplies for the actual scientists to set up when they arrive.

Catra would've loved to watch it happen.

Adora takes a deep breath, preparing herself to try and explain her spacing-out in Space. It's not an easy topic, and her friends have always been there for her, understanding, never prodding too hard when the subject was Adora's ex-girlfriend.

'Whenever I'm out there,' she begins, trying to find the words to describe exactly how it makes her feel, 'I don't know, it's like I'm

closer to her.' Adora sighs, placing her hand against the thick triple paned silica glass, watching the way it fogs up around her hand's warmth. 'I know it's stupid, but this station is the closest I'll get to her for another five years. That's if she even wants to see me when she gets back, which she made pretty clear the last time we spoke that she doesn't. I just…' Adora stares out into Space for a moment, grateful for her friends' silence and consideration, the last conversation she had with Catra playing through her mind again before she can stop it—

"Just, promise me this one thing, Adora."

And what could Adora say but, *"Anything."*

"Don't wait for me."

Adora distinctly remembers the way her stomach dropped at those words, the way her heart leapt into her throat, the way she froze and could feel the colour drain from her face. Whenever she remembers them, it leaves a sour taste in her mouth and her gut wrenches uncomfortably. Four words, and Adora's world came crashing down around her.

"Catra…"

"No, you have to promise me!" There was a fire in Catra's eyes as she spoke, *"I can't go out there thinking that you'll just waste your life waiting for me to come back."* A fire, but also sadness, pain. Adora could see it. Recognise it. *"There's more for you here, Adora. You'll do amazing things, meet an amazing person."* The words hurt more because Adora knew Catra didn't want to say them. She knew that Catra truly believed she was doing the right thing, asking this of Adora. *"You'll live your life! Promise me you'll* live *, Adora."*

But Catra *was* Adora's life. Over the years, Catra became Adora's entire world. Catra was *everything* .

Until she wasn't.

"Okay. I promise."

Adora lied.

—and she tried to live without Catra, without thinking about her everyday, tried to move on from her, to date other people but… it was hard. Moving on from Catra was the hardest thing Adora ever tried to do. So she stopped trying. As soon as she heard that Dryl was looking for experienced people with exactly Adora's education and experience, she applied for the position. It took less than a year for her to learn how to apply what she already knew to a zero-gravity environment, and she spent the rest of the time learning some of what Bow was training for. He could do the smaller, fiddlier parts of repairs, but Adora was able to help with the larger, less technical aspects.

'I just can't help but wait for her,' Adora continues when she feels like she can speak again, her voice laden with emotion and her eyes wet with unshed tears. 'I *have* to wait for her. I love her.'

'Adora,' Glimmer starts again, shrugging off the warning hand from Bow that he rests on her shoulder, 'Catra broke up with you three years ago and told you to move on. Now, I admire everything you've done in that time, in the year we've been up here together, but what are you going to do if– *when* she gets back?'

Adora wipes at her eyes as Glimmer's words sink in. It's not the first time she's had this talk, but it never gets any easier. 'I have to believe she'll want to be friends again, at least, if she doesn't love me anymore. If she doesn't want me like I want her. I just want her *back* . She's the single-most important person in my life, she means more to me than she'll ever know, and it's killing me that I can't tell her that.'

As Adora desperately tries not to cry, Bow and Glimmer exchange a sad look. They hate to see their friend so torn up about the love of her life, the one who broke up with her before blasting off to explore the galaxy. Bow, especially, understands why Catra did it.

They're all told, reminded, throughout their training that they might not get the chance to return to Etheria. The mission that Catra left on was statistically doomed. She must have known that, somehow, found it out from somewhere further up the security clearance ladder. Bow believes that Catra was trying to provide Adora with a kindness—a kind of closure—because part of her believed that she wouldn't be coming back at all. Anything can go wrong in Space, it's the most hostile and unforgiving environment ever explored, and Catra knew that. Knew the risks. *She must have been trying to be kind.*

Bow clears his throat, leaning forward a little in order to not startle Adora with words that may upset her more. 'Adora…' he began, looking back at Glimmer as if to make sure that what he was about to suggest was okay to say. They must have talked about it at some point beforehand, because Glimmer seemed to understand, nodding her approval. 'Adora,' Bow started again, 'have you considered sending Catra a message?'

Adora nods, because of course she has. She thinks about it every time she gets her own message from Catra's mums, where they tell her about any old random thing they've done recently. But what really gets her is when they update her on Catra too. They send messages to Catra, and Catra *replies* . They say the video quality is never great, but hearing Catra's voice and recognising her on the other side of the short video gives them peace of mind that she's *okay* , that she's still out there and *"can't wait to come home"* .

So, yes. Adora's thought about it before. It has kept her awake some nights, just thinking about what she would say, to the point where she's had to write down the words to stop them from endlessly looping around in her head.

Mostly, Adora writes about how she misses her best friend, but sometimes, Adora writes about how she still loves Catra too. She wonders if Catra thinks about her, if she wonders how she's doing. She wonders if her mums tell her what Adora tells them she's up

to, that she's also in Space now, just not as far, but she isn't sure they would without asking first.

She hopes they don't. Adora's dreads the day when Catra learns she never kept her promise to move on and live without her. She's scared that Catra will push her away for good when she comes back, that Adora failing to move on will be the final nail in the coffin that is their relationship, whatever that may be.

She's scared, but she also hopes that Catra will understand, forgive her. What they had, you don't just find that again. Catra was always it for Adora, and she always will be.

Catra, 4 years after the Serenia 2's launch

They're ahead of schedule.

The logs on board the Serenia 2 suggest they've been out here for four years now which, truth be told, doesn't sound right, because they've only been out of stasis for maybe a year total. But it *is* , it's correct. Catra double checks the dates in the shuttle's log three times to be sure, and then she cross-references that with the latest data from Etheria.

They've been away for four years, relatively speaking, but she estimates that about six have passed back home. The thought kind of makes her want to cry.

Six years.

That’s enough time for Adora to have found a stable job, to have found someone new, to get settled down, and start a family. It’s enough time for her to move on from Catra, to live her life, just like Catra made her promise to do. Her mothers tell her that Adora’s doing fine in their messages, that she has a job, friends, a *life* . Adora is *living her life* , and Catra aches that she isn’t part of it like she was supposed to be.

This time, when she finishes checking the data and retreats to her bed, she doesn’t stop the tears when they come.

Usually, waking up from stasis is no issue. They’ve done it four times so far, each time stopping on a planet for two or three Etherian months at a time, and usually Catra’s fine. This time, however, Catra woke up crying. She blames the dreams. They’re so vivid, so *real,* the product of their induced comatose state that slows down their aging but not quite stopping it. Catra routinely dreams of Adora, their memories, the things they used to get up to. Catra dreamt of Adora this time too, but not their past; their future. The future they always talked about. Living together, laughing together, going out on dates, having movie nights in. Catra dreamt of marrying the girl she’s still hopelessly in love with, and she cried when she woke up because it *felt real* but it *wasn’t* and she *wants it so bad* but *can’t have it* anymore and—

—and it’s her fault.

She told Scorpia. She *had to* . Catra was almost completely inconsolable and wouldn’t get out of the stasis pod at first, so an explanation seemed appropriate. Scorpia was quiet for a while after Catra told her that she’s still hopelessly in love with the girl she left behind, that she broke up with. Catra thinks she knows why. The shuttle is pretty small and personal space is lackluster so the three of them are pretty close now, but the way Scorpia blushes when Catra laughs can’t be explained easily, and Catra doesn’t really want to think about it.

Instead, she focuses on how they’re a day or two out from their final stop. They don't have much designated space left in the

shuttle for samples, and only a couple larger crates for bigger samples remain, but they still have to go down there and finish the mission. After all, once they finish this, they can go home.

That'll show them.

When Catra overheard one of the scientists talking to the training facility's chief of staff about the likelihood of her team's success, Catra almost burst in there to ask if they really had that little faith in them. But, when she thought about it more, she realised that even the most skilled team couldn't survive something unexpected going wrong. Her mind reeled for days about all the ways she could die in space, on a voyage that would last eight years on Etheria. The realisation that some people didn't expect them to return was a heavy one, but she shouldered it anyway.

And then there was Adora.

Adora gave her full support to Catra's training to go into Space, even knowing how long she'd be away for, and for some reason Catra hadn't really thought about just how long eight years was to keep someone waiting, especially when she might not actually make it home at all. So Catra ended things, gave Adora a way out of their relationship, so that she could live without waiting for her girlfriend who may never come back. It was the right thing to do, even if it was the last thing Catra wanted.

Of course she wanted Adora to be there when she got back, waiting to hold her, to kiss her, to tell her that she loves her, that she always has and always will. She wants that so bad it *hurts* . She misses Adora, her smile, her warmth, the feeling of safety, of *home.* Catra misses Adora with a passion, a burning ache in her chest that just won't leave her alone. She realises that she *doesn't want it to go* . The idea of letting go now makes her feel sick, so she clings to the hope that she can make it home, and maybe Adora will want to see her again. Maybe they can be friends. Catra can meet whoever Adora fell in love with after Catra broke her heart, and she can be a part of Adora's life again.

But that thought only makes Catra hurt more, because that's *not what she wants* . Some stupid, selfish part of her wants Adora all to herself, even though she doesn't deserve that, not after what she did. She made Adora *promise* to move on from her, for crying out loud, so blindly hoping that Adora will still want her the same way Catra does is a fool's endeavour. It's pointless, but she needs to hold on to it. *She needs it.*

Sometimes, when they're on approach to a planet, or have just left and are making sure everything is fine before setting their new course and "hitting the hay" for a year or so, Catra works out which direction points back to Etheria. She keeps track, both for herself and for the logs. More than once, she's considered just putting in the course to take them all home and abandon the mission entirely, but she doesn't. Scorpia and Entrapta are committed to finishing the mission. Scorpia seems convinced they'll be welcomed back like some kind of heroes, all parades and flags and trumpets. Entrapta just wants to analyse some of the stuff she's found back in her lab, which she's certain will still be just as she left it when they return home. Catra… Catra knows what she wants. But the thought of going back, only to find she can't have it, keeps her on task. She's procrastinating facing reality, on a galactic scale.

Sometimes, though, when Scorpia and Entrapta are busy or asleep, Catra looks out in the direction she's worked out Etheria to be, just to see if she can spot it. It's too far, though, obviously, the distance so large she doesn't like thinking about it. But still, sometimes Catra looks out into their galaxy anyway, wondering about how she used to preach to Adora that it wasn't empty, that it was full to the brim with life and adventure. She thinks about how wrong she was, that it really *is* empty, that Adora was right all along. She feels incredibly small, insignificant, so desperately alone.

Forgotten.

That's where Catra is, just daydreaming about blonde hair and blue eyes while staring out the viewport in the general direction of

Etheria, when Entrapta says, ‘Ooooh. That’s not good.’

Catra’s ears immediately stand to attention and she pushes away from the small window to float through the shuttle toward the bridge (they stopped calling it the “cockpit” pretty early on) where Entrapta was keeping an eye on their approach to the last planet of the trip. This one is a deep, swirling red, but their instruments are telling them that beneath the thick cloud cover, there *is* solid ground to land on. Catra isn’t too worried about navigating clouds, even if the conditions are stormy, she’s handled landing and taking off enough times now to confidently land it in any condition. The one thing she hasn’t had to maneuver yet, however, is a large, volatile, unpredictable—

‘It’s an asteroid belt!’

Yeah. *That.*

‘And a large one too! For some reason the sensors didn’t detect them and now we’re heading straight for it! Oh dear, this is not good.’ Entrapta starts chewing on one of her long purple pigtails, a nervous tick that wasn’t quite so obvious when her hair was in a pixie cut back when the Serenia 2 first launched. They all had to have almost completely shaved heads back then, but now each of them has their own style. Catra’s is usually tied back in a ponytail, whereas Scorpia actually seems to prefer hers short, keeping it shaved on the sides with a tuft of white fluff on top. What’s ground control going to do? Send someone to tell them off?

‘Can’t we go around?’ Catra asks, floating forwards to get a better look out the forward windscreen. Fuck. There really are *a lot* of rocks out there. How did they miss this?

‘That’s a negative, we’re already too close to the belt to avoid it with our current momentum and trajectory. It’s one of the largest asteroid belts I’ve ever seen. As the autopilot is set to take a linear route, my advice would be to—’

‘Yeah, yeah, I know. Guide us through manually,’ Catra finishes, sighing and flipping herself round in the zero gravity until she’s seated in the pilot chair. She pulls on the yoke, and disables the autopilot, ‘I have control.’

‘You have control!’ Entrapta confirms, a little too excitedly for Catra’s liking.

Catra takes a deep breath, readying herself to focus on the emergency unfolding in front of her. From what she can see, the asteroids aren’t moving quickly, but vary in size and shape. Some are huge, dwarfing the Serenia, and some are tiny, maybe car sized. No doubt that also means there’s even smaller rocks that she can’t see.

Great. Any debris at all in Space is deadly, so this is basically their worst nightmare. If any of those rocks hit the wrong part of the ship, they could be screwed.

‘How exactly did we miss this?!’ Catra shouts, her frustration growing alongside her sense of dread.

‘My hypothesis,’ Entrapta starts, looking back at her instruments, ‘is that they are made of a material that the scans can’t identify, so we didn’t know they were there until the proximity sensors detected them! AHAHAHA! I wonder what they’re made of! Perhaps it can be repurposed to allow entire aircraft to completely drop off of radar! Ooooh, the *possibilities* !’

Catra scoffs, because there’s no way on—well, *in Space* —that they’re going to be able to actually get a sample of the rocks *outside* the shuttle.

Just as Catra grips the yoke, just as she focuses in on a possible opening they may just fit through in the swirling swarm of space rocks, a loud and cheery, ‘hey guys!’, booms from right behind them, making Catra jump and the shuttle lurch to the left alarmingly fast.

Catra rushes to correct their course before they're permanently thrown off. As soon as she's happy, she releases the breath she was holding in a loud, annoyed sigh before turning to level Scorpia with a glare that Catra *swears* could kill if only she could perfect it. To say that Scorpia looks apologetic would be an understatement. Mistakes like that could cost them more than a stable route through a planet's asteroid belt. Any mistake in Space could be your last, and startling the person in charge of their tin-can hurtling through Space is not the way to stay alive.

'Scorpia, what the fuck?!' Catra roars, because *what the fuck?*

'Uh, um– I, uhm–' Scorpia stammers, struggling to find the words to defend herself. She's holding one of their squeezy tubes of weird space food that's supposed to last forever between her pincers, midway through what Catra is guessing to be one of the scorpioni's three daily meals.

Scorpia is much larger than Catra and Entrapta combined—*probably* —so the labcoats back on Etheria packed Scorpia with her own special food packets, as well as more of them in total. Catra and Entrapta share from the standard rations, but Catra usually ends up eating more as Entrapta only eats hers in tiny chunks yet seems to get full quicker. Catra isn't complaining though—more food for her, right?

'Whatever, I don't care,' Catra dismisses the pained look on Scorpia's face with a flick of her wrist and turns back to stare down their current—and potentially most deadly to date—life or death scenario. 'Just *please* sit down, I'm taking evasive action.'

'Yes, boss! Right away, you gotcha!' Scorpia rushes, hurrying to swing her bulky frame into the last remaining free chair on the bridge, securing her seatbelts to ensure she doesn't float away. 'Ready!'

'Okay,' Catra whispers, pointedly ignoring how Scorpia is still calling her "boss" despite her only being a pilot and glorified weed-picker, ducking down in her seat to watch as the first

asteroid passes overhead, a safe distance away from the Serenia. That's it. They're within the planet's asteroid belt, no turning back. Catra takes a final deep breath, gripping the yoke again while scanning ahead for a safe route through. 'Let's do this.'

———————

'Hey, Uh— Entrapta? Buddy? Lights are going off, what does it mean?' Scorpia asks, a panicked edge to her voice as she eyes the lights on a nearby panel slowly blinking off one by one every time another small asteroid hits the shuttle.

'I will assess all damage once we are safely landed!' Entrapta replies from between her knees. She's folded herself into the brace position, the one they're trained to take if they're going to crash, even though they're nowhere near the planet's surface yet and Catra keeps insisting she's handling it. 'I would suggest focusing on avoiding the larger asteroids in particular, the probability of survival after a head-on collision with one of them is very low.'

'You think?!' Catra yells over her shoulder as she steers their vessel sharply to the right, avoiding yet another death-sized space rock.

Catra, in her defence, has been able to avoid all the asteroids that would no-doubt decimate the Serenia, but those smaller, fist-sized rocks are kicking her ass. Luckily, they don't seem strong enough to damage the glass, or leave anything more than shallow dents in the exterior, but even Catra knows that even the smallest dent in the wrong place could have devastating consequences for some of the ship's external equipment that has to extend out from underneath protective panels. Protective panels that aren't as thick as the rest of the ship. It's the only flaw Catra could see in the design, but it wasn't supposed to be an issue. The Serenia 2

was built to be an exploration and research craft, not a space-rock bulldozer. Catra is just worried about one thing in particular, but she's trying not to think about that too hard while she concentrates on just getting them through this ordeal alive.

After another few minutes of what Catra considers to be some of the best flying of her life, they're through. The occupants of the Serenia 2 are unscathed, but Catra fears for the ship itself.

'Entrapta, what's the damage—'

'Please just land!' Entrapta squeaks, her voice panicked and words rushed, 'I'll do a full system sweep when we're on the ground. Please just land!'

Catra nods. She understands all too well why Entrapta is shaken and Scorpia is still silent behind her. They just almost *died* , after all. But now isn't the time to dwell on that; now Catra has to focus on bringing them in *slowly* , not fighting against this new planet's atmosphere too hard lest the heat and winds damage anything further. It's impossible to know what the outside of the ship looks like, and until they do Catra has to be careful.

———————

The entry was choppy, to say the least. The cloud cover was thick and red—some kind of ash, according to Entrapta, possibly thrown into the atmosphere by some kind of tectonic shift or volcanic eruption—which made visibility a *bitch* . Catra handled it though, the spotlights toward the front of the Serenia guided their way through the opaque wall of red, until they lit up an area of flat, red rock, on which Catra gently set them down as quickly as she dared. Usually, the crew of the Serenia would have a lot more time, and a lot more visibility, to properly assess their options in terms of landing sites. This time however, they just needed to *land* .

Scorpia and Catra wordlessly leave Entrapta to run her tests, walking through to the hold to start preparing the crates they would need. Each of them filled with smaller, more secure crates, which in turn were filled with the even smaller, sterilised containers that they'll be using to store the samples inside. They only have two large crates left, so those are the ones that Catra untethers from the floor of the hold, ready for Scorpia to carry outside.

Once they're ready to go, Catra eyes her spacesuit, wondering if the atmosphere outside is breathable or not. Judging by the thick red ash cover they flew through, it's definitely the safer bet to wear one anyway, just in case. The last thing they need is their lungs clogged with some kind of red, alien ash.

They would usually consult Entrapta, but Entrapta still seems pretty shaken from the planetary entry and would probably be unresponsive for a while. Checking through the shuttle systems and repairing anything that's broken would probably be the best thing for her right now anyway, it gives her something to focus on that *isn't* the fact that they almost died.

Scorpia, already wearing her spacesuit, except for the helmet, sits dejectedly on one of the crates opposite Catra, staring down at a bottle of protein pills she's holding between a pincer like it's about to start telling her something. They all have them, as the tubes of space food don't quite have *everything* included that they need to stay fit and healthy, alongside the limited exercise that they get while awake. Catra's been trying not to think too hard about the state of the ship, but Scorpia being quiet like this doesn't help to subdue her inner thoughts and worries.

Catra kind of just wants to get on with their tasks, but Scorpia is the only one of the three of them who's actually strong enough to lift these crates when gravity is so insistent on keeping them for itself. So, Catra runs a hand through her hair, and gears herself up to try being a good friend. For a change.

‘Scorp, you doing okay? Um… buddy?’ Catra threw in the— *what? Term of endearment?* —that Scorpia sometimes uses for her and Entrapta in a second attempt to get Scorpia’s attention after the initial question didn’t garner a response.

‘How bad do you think the damage is?’ Are the words that leave Scorpia’s mouth, and if Catra didn’t have *incredible* hearing, she would have missed them entirely with how quietly they were mumbled.

‘I don’t know, Scorp,’ Catra shrugs, because until they step outside, or until Entrapta finishes her system checks inside, there really is no way to know. ‘How about you just help me do this and we’ll find out together when Entrapta’s done, yeah?’

That does the trick. Scorpia perks up a little, stepping down off the crate she’d chosen to perch on and crosses the hold to where Catra is standing, next to the spacesuits. She’s still eyeing the bottle of pills, which starts to worry Catra until their eyes meet and Scorpia smiles sadly. Catra nods, because she’s pretty sure Scorpia’s worrying about the same thing she is, that the ship may be damaged in some vital way, and the wait to find out is excruciating to say the least.

‘Scorpia,’ Catra ventures, her voice soft and hopefully reassuring, ‘it’ll be fine. Just, take your protein pills and put your helmet on. Please. We’ve got work to do.’

Scorpia nods, flicking the lid on the bottle and swallowing down her required dosage before placing the bottle on top of the spacesuit lockers and grabbing her helmet from inside. She prepares the crates while Catra pulls on her spacesuit and helmet, dragging them over to the entrance and setting them down where she can easily lift them to carry them out of the shuttle. After Catra double checks the airlock between the hold and the rest of the shuttle, showing Scopria a thumbs up when she determines that it’s safely locked and no air from outside will get into the rest of the craft, Scorpia hits the red button beside the ramp. A red light flashes overhead as the clamps disengage, and Scorpia

secures her helmet over her head just as the first rush of alien air forces its way through the tiny gaps around the ramp as it slowly lowers down to the ground outside.

Catra makes her way forward, nodding to Scorpia to start unloading, and cautiously descends the ramp and onto the last planet of their mission.

The first thing Catra notices as she steps down onto the harsh, cracked surface of the barren, red planet they've found themselves on, is how quiet everything is. There's little wind, which means the particles in the air are moving more like dust than ash, as if a crimson fog has descended over the entire area. The fog is thinner down here than it was in the upper atmosphere, the lights from the Serenia illuminating the immediate area, but there's little to see. It reminds Catra of the desert back on Etheria, the Crimson Waste, except this is, somehow, even more dead. At least in the Crimson Waste, there's supposed to be things living there. Animals, people, whatever. But here? There's nothing here. It's as if the entire planet died and they're standing on its corpse.

Her boots leave imprints in the ground, as if she's stepping on snow. But it isn't snow, it's just layer upon layer of umber ash, masking the scarlet rocks beneath. As she kicks the ash away, bending down to trail her gloved fingers over the jagged surface of the ground, it doesn't settle immediately. Rather, it spreads out, floating back into the air around her.

The ash is acting as if the planet has low-gravity, but it doesn't, because Catra isn't affected. Yes, the ash is far lighter than Catra, but even back on Etheria ash wouldn't act this weightless. It wouldn't float in the air with no breeze to carry it, no fire to fly away from. It would descend.

A wave of ash sweeps around and between Catra's legs, and she turns to see Scorpia placing their crates on the ground behind her, a good distance away from the ship. Catra swallows and clears

her throat. The last thing she wants is Scorpia hearing how shaken Catra is by some floaty red snow.

'We should stay a while,' says the Catra who's a part of the crew of the Serenia 2, the Catra who has a mission, the Catra whose mission it is to study this planet, despite how weird it is. 'Maybe the fog will lift eventually, and then we can actually see if there's anything else around.'

Catra watches as Scorpia nods within her helmet, but the helmet doesn't actually move. Her suit is larger than Catra's, specially made, and the helmet secures to the base of her neck, unlike Catra and Entrapta's suits. It kind of makes it look like she's wearing a fish-tank, but Catra's not about to point that out.

In looking back toward Scorpia, however, Catra accidentally gets her first good look at the outside of the Serenia 2. It's—

Honestly, Catra was expecting much worse. The exterior of the ship certainly went through some damage, but it doesn't look anywhere near as bad as Catra was expecting. Apparently the Serenia's hull is tougher than she gave it credit for.

'Catra!' Comes the shrill voice in her ear, always too loud, making her wince in surprise, 'could you check the communications dish on the outside of Darla? I'm detecting issues with deploying it.'

'Sure thing,' Catra replies over the comms, meeting Scorpia's suddenly worried gaze again for a fraction of a second as she moves to walk around to the other side of the ship where the panel covering the dish is situated.

As Catra rounds the ship, her stomach drops, because this side is much worse for wear than the other and the communications dish is…well–The whole panel, including the communications dish itself, is just– it's—

'It's gone, Entrapta,' even as Catra says the words, she feels her heart rise up into her throat as she tries not to cry. 'It's just… *gone* .'

That's it. They really are alone out here now. If they weren't already on the last planet of the voyage, they would have to cancel the mission and head home anyway, because Catra needs the data from that dish to calculate their exact position. Luckily for the crew of the Serenia, she did it an hour or two before the sensors detected the asteroid belt, so she'll still be able to program the autopilot with a fairly accurate destination. Give or take a few thousand miles.

But that isn't what makes tears prick at the corners of her eyes. No. Because they've lost more than the ability to receive data from Etheria; they've lost the ability to receive messages from their loved ones. A tear rolls down Catra's cheek as she realises that she won't be able to receive any new messages, or send them, the entire way back. The return journey will be the longest single flight of the Serenia's trip, as they're currently on the farthest planet, so the stasis chambers will wake them up two or three times along the way to check the systems are all good and the samples are safe.

'Who did you speak to?' Scorpia asks, having appeared close by and Catra just blinks at her because…

This whole time, she's been thinking that she's alone. Even knowing that Scorpia and Entrapta are here with her, Catra still felt alone. But, now that the only thing that made her feel some connection to Etheria is gone, Catra realises that she isn't alone. Not really. She never has been, she just chose to think that. Maybe it made it easier, being away, keeping her crew at a distance. But distance is the last thing she wants right now. The idea of keeping Scorpia at arms length for any longer makes her feel sick, because the reality is that Catra just wants to go home.

Home.

What is *home* to Catra?

Home is warmth, safety, love. Home is blonde hair, blue eyes, and a radiant smile.

Can you feel homesick for a person? Or is it just the longing to be in their arms again bubbling to the surface? Catra should have sent her a message, a video, something. *Anything* . When was the last time Catra heard Adora's voice?

"Okay. I promise."

No. No, that can't be it.

It can't… but it *is* .

'My mothers,' Catra says, aware that her ragged breathing is starting to fog up her helmet's visor. She's partly grateful, it means Scorpia won't see her cry for a moment. 'Just my mothers.'

There's a moment of peace that falls between them, but it's heavy with emotion. Catra doesn't think she can say anything more without sobbing into her helmet.

'It's the same for me,' Scorpia's gentle voice tells her, 'I've got two mothers too, and they would send just so *many* messages, asking how I was, what I'm doing, how things back home are.'

Catra nods, swallowing down the sob that wants to escape, even as tears begin falling down her face without her permission. 'We'll see them again, Scorp,' Catra promises, 'we'll see them again.'

'Yeah, you're right. It'll just be hard to go so long without hearing from them, you know?' Scorpia asks, staring up at the place where their communications dish is supposed to be.

And, Catra does know, but she needs a moment to gather her thoughts, to work up the courage to keep going, even though she just wants to give up, leave, rush home as fast as she can.

'I'm going to go, uh, sort through my head a bit,' Catra says, starting to walk back around to the back of the shuttle.

‘I’ll unload the crates,’ Scorpia replies, and when Catra turns back around to tell her that she really doesn’t need to if she wants a moment Scopria just holds up her pincers, ‘I’m fine, I just need to do something to occupy myself while I process, you know?’

So, Catra nods, and heads back into the ship alone.

It’s only after Catra’s gone though the process of re-entering the ship (securing the airlock and going through the decontamination process for both her and her suit) that she realises Entrapta has been quiet ever since Catra told her the dish was gone. She doesn’t have trouble finding her crewmate, however, her nose easily guiding her, but Catra isn’t expecting to find Entrapta where she does.

Entrapta is curled up into a ball, huddled underneath a mass of wires sticking out from below a panel covered with controls, silently crying into her knees. Catra had never seen Entrapta cry, or show any emotion other than pure, unbridled joy and excitement to be on this voyage. So Catra forgets her own grief and surprises herself. She enters friend-mode again, rushing forward to pull Entrapta out from her cocoon of tech and into an awkward hug. Catra doesn’t have to say anything, Entrapta just starts talking, telling her about how this lab-partner of hers would send her updates on what he’s working on, filing for patents, conducting the same tests over and over and over again until he got a new result. To Catra, they sound boring, repetitive, something she could easily fall asleep listening to. But to Entrapta? To Entrapta, they meant everything, gave her something to hold on to, to look forward to everyday they weren’t in stasis. Catra finds she can’t hold back her own tears either.

All they have now is each other. They’ll get through this and get back to the people they care about, the people they love, if only to hear their voices again. They have to.

They have to.

Bow, 7 years after the Serenia 2's launch

Bow doesn't think anything of it when he receives a call from his wife to come up to her office, but when he finds Adora in there too his interest is most certainly piqued.

'Guess who slunk in here not fifteen minutes ago to ask me for a certain someone's comm code?' Glimmer asks him, raising an eyebrow and looking way too smug about the whole thing.

Adora just looks guilty, wringing her hands together while shuffling a little in the seat behind Glimmer's desk.

'Why now?' Bow asks the room, because it's the only question he can think to ask. Both he and Glimmer are of the opinion that Adora should have bitten the bullet and sent a communication years ago, so why she's decided to do it now seems very out of the blue.

Glimmer glances back to Adora and raises a questioning brow, clearly agreeing with her husband that, *yes* , that is the best question to ask. Bow moves further into the room after locking the door behind him with a swipe of his clearance pass, and sits down gently in the chair next to Adora's. She looks… pensive. Reserved. Nervous.

'She's supposed to get back next year,' Adora says, her voice small, yet hopeful, 'I got a message from her mothers the other week, and they said they haven't had a video back from her for a while so… I don't know, I just figured I would tell her how things are now, with me, with Arxia. Tell her about you guys. Just so she isn't caught off guard when she gets back.'

Bow and Glimmer exchange a glance, and Glimmer gives him her silent permission to ask what they're both thinking. They both know that Bow is the more eloquent of the two of them, gentler, it's no fault of Glimmer's, really, she just gets impatient with people sometimes.

'What about the promise?' Bow asks, his voice low and soft. Adora swallows. He knows that they haven't really talked about Catra in a while, about everything that happened, but if Adora's acting like this then she must still have feelings for her, whoever she is. Bow can't help but feel sorry for her. He knows that doesn't help, so "sorry" is the last thing he's going to say, but he's known the woman sitting across from him for six years now and in all that time he doesn't ever think he's seen her really *happy* .

'I never kept the promise,' Adora says sadly, looking down at her hands, 'Not really. So I'll just be honest with her. I'll tell her how it is, how I feel, and I guess… I guess we'll see.'

And… yeah, okay. That sounds good to Bow, and a quick glance to his wife tells him that she thinks the same. Adora being open about her feelings with the person she's having them for *is* a good thing. Granted, she's doing it across Space and won't see the other party for around another year, but it's a step in the right direction. Space and the distance it brings makes communication tricky, and this scenario is an entirely unique one.

'Do you need anything?' Glimmer asks, typing something on the glass keyboard on her desk before scrolling down a long list of *something* . Bow's pretty sure she's looking for Catra's comm code, but it isn't used very often and uses a pretty outdated system these days.

The question is kind of open ended, but Adora seems to understand that. She thinks for a moment, her brows furrowing, before she glances up and looks Bow in the eye for maybe the second time since he walked in. 'Could I borrow Bow to help me set everything up?'

Bow's eyes widen a fraction when he realises that the question wasn't directed at him, and Glimmer says, 'sure thing!' He rolls his eyes fondly, because it's not like would have opposed the request anyway. 'I'll send the code through to your datapad when I'm ready, I just have to request a couple of satellites be realigned in the meantime. One of them is *a little outdated* ,' Glimmer continues, mumbling that last part under her breath, 'but all should be fine.'

Adora nods, offering a small smile to Glimmer in thanks before glancing back to Bow.

'Well then,' he says, standing up and readying his pass to unlock the door again, 'let's get you all set up and ready.'

———————

The walk from Glimmer's office—that's right, Glimmer has an *office* now. She was recently promoted and Bow is extremely proud of her, even if a lot of her time is taken up now by practically running Arxia singlehanded—isn't too long, the elevators and the soon-to-be-installed monorails around the Spaceport making short work of any long distance travel.

Bow is still dumbstruck when he considers how large Arxia is now. He remembers when they first arrived five years ago, how small it was back then, but the scientists and engineers down on Etheria never stopped improving the tech and finding more efficient ways to get materials up into Space. Now, their old capsule, the original Arxia station, is practically forgotten and soon to be decommissioned, scrapped and taken back down to Etheria so they can re-use the parts. Bow sometimes goes back up there, just to think, but he won't be able to for long. Maybe he'll take Glimmer up there again soon, one last time, as a treat.

It may also be one of the last times, for a while, that they experience zero gravity. After the successful implementation of an artificial gravity generator, located in the centre of Arxia's almost three-quarter complete circular design, the Arxia Spaceport was opened for public use and is now a vibrant and lively hub of activity. They're still constructing most of the habitation on Etheria's moons, and all those supplies go through Arxia too, but they still get a good number of tourists visiting and the bigger businesses are always eager to open their first branches in the Spaceport when a new unit becomes available, the right to rent the space often falling to a bidding war. Bow keeps out of all that though, it's not his department. What his department *does* do, is keep the lights on. He's now head-engineer, and oversees the majority of essential resources. Electricity, water, food, waste recycling. Nothing is wasted on Arxia, and if you were to ask Bow what his plans are, he'd say that he hopes they can be fully self-sufficient by the time construction on Arxia's main ring is complete.

Bow often describes the Arxia Spaceport as "just an airport in space" because of the similarities in security as well as how capitalism has dug its greedy fangs into it, and everyone usually agrees with that assessment.

Adora was never as interested in running Arxia as Bow and Glimmer were, however, and with the influx of new engineers she even took a step back to focus on her PT work. She makes sure that the people, staff and visitors alike, are taking care of themselves and keeping active, even in Space.

When Bow asks his friend where she would be most comfortable recording the message, Adora tells him that her quarters are probably the best bet, so that's where they go.

Adora's quarters don't seem very personal to her, as she never brought much up from Etheria and isn't one to hoard things, but there are a few photographs up on the wall of her and another girl, a magicat, from when she was younger. Adora's smiling in all of the pictures, and it wouldn't take a genius to work out exactly

who the other girl is, but this is what Bow means when he thinks he's never seen Adora really, truly happy. He's never seen *that* smile.

Not once, in the six years he's known her.

There isn't much to set up. Adora elects to just sit on the edge of her bed, and Bow leans the datapad against some books on the desk across from her.

'Okay…' he says, slowly backing away from the datapad for the third time in case it falls again, 'we're all good to go. Do you want me to stay with you while you do it?'

Adora shakes her head, 'no, that's okay. I think I'll focus better on my own and I need a minute to think anyway.'

'Alright. I'll be right outside if you need me, okay?' Bow assures her, placing a reassuring hand on her shoulder and offering a kind smile. Adora smiles back and nods, her eyes already glistening with unshed tears.

'Actually,' Adora says, grabbing Bow's wrist before he can move away too far, 'could I have a hug?'

'Always.'

Bow sits outside Adora's door for maybe thirty minutes after he hugs her and leaves to allow her the privacy she needs to say the words she needs to say. He thinks about how Adora clung to him, and with an ache in his chest he realises it must be months since they last hugged. He makes a mental note to ensure that he keeps checking in on Adora over the next year. It'll be the moment of truth, after all. If Catra is fine, if everything went to

plan, they should be back. But Catra's lack of communication has him worried. Both for Catra herself, and for what will happen to Adora if Catra *doesn't* come back. She's always been open with them about things, but he realises that, along with the hugs, they haven't hung out as much. All three of them have been busy with new responsibilities, and it's eating up the time they would normally spend together.

The mumbling that he can hear through Adora's door is faint, but he thinks he hears her restart two or three times, and the datapad definitely falls over again once or twice. Whatever Adora's saying in there, Bow hopes she's being honest. Mincing her words, or saying things she doesn't mean, is the absolute last thing she should do in this situation. But he trusts her to follow her heart. She's followed it this far, it just so happens that Arxia is as close as she can get.

When Adora calls for Bow to come back in, she's sitting on her bed, her face illuminated as she looks down solemnly at the datapad screen. It's clear she's been crying, so Bow is careful as he approaches.

'I sent it,' Adora whispers, looking up at Bow just as another tear rolls down her cheek. 'Bow, I sent it.'

Bow immediately crosses the room, sitting down next to Adora on the bed and pulls her into a tight embrace. She returns the hug easily, burying her face against his shoulder as she lets the tears fall.

'Bow…' she whimpers, her voice shaky and wobbling, 'what do I do if she doesn't reply? What do I do…'

'We keep going,' he replies, because he doesn't know what else to say, 'we keep going.'

Glimmer, 10 years after the Serenia 2's launch

Glimmer worries about her friend.

Adora's a ghost of herself these days, just working robotically, as if existing has lost its purpose and she's just going through the motions, running on muscle memory alone.

And Glimmer knows *why* .

Ever since Adora stopped asking, stopped checking if Catra's ship had docked or was close or anything, she closed herself off. Glimmer's heart aches for her friend, it really does, but she wasn't surprised when she realised what had happened, what had changed. Honestly, part of her was relieved.

She hates that she initially felt relief when Adora gave up, after holding on for so long. Never losing hope, not once. But after three years of no communication, after two years of no logs of the Serenia 2 entering the system, even Adora had reached her limit.

Glimmer knocks on her friend's door one night, intent on checking in with her, and sighs a little as the door slides open to reveal Adora curled up into a ball on her bed, shrouded in darkness with her viewports shuttered closed, blocking the view out into Space. That sight told Glimmer all she needed to know, really. Adora never used to close her shutters, once saying she actually slept better with them open. But, here she is, laying in the dark, her window into Space, to Catra, literally closed.

The door hisses shut behind her as Glimmer makes her way further into the room. She sits on the edge of the bed slowly, trying not to startle Adora with her sudden intrusion. Glimmer sighs, looking down at her hands in the room's gloom, realising

that the nail polish she used was actually a little bit glow in the dark.

'She's dead.'

Glimmer closes her eyes as Adora speaks, hanging her head as if to hide her face, even in the darkness.

'She's never coming back.'

As if in some kind of defiance, Glimmer shakes her head. Maybe it's the guilt talking, but part of her always kind of thought that Catra wouldn't come back. She feels bad about that now, that it actually came true, seeing the toll that it's taking on someone who could've been so vibrant if only the light of her life wasn't taken away so many years ago.

'And I've wasted my life, just like she made me promise not to.'

Adora's voice breaks on the last part of that sentence and she barely finishes it before she can't talk through her silent crying. Glimmer almost joins her. She isn't cut out for this, where's Bow when she needs him?

'There's no way to know, and you haven't wasted anything,' is all that Glimmer can think to say. She realises that she's crying too, and her voice is thick with the emotion that comes with realising that Adora is *in mourning* for the love of her life.

'I know it sucks,' Glimmer continues, just trying to fill the silence at this point, 'I know it sucks, but we have to—'

'What?!' Adora shouts, her voice suddenly harsh and lacking in empathy. 'We have to *what?! Keep going?* What do you know, Glimmer?' Glimmer recoils when Adora turns over in her bed, sitting up to stare down at her, 'you've had your family visit Arxia countless times! So has Bow! I don't—' and that's when Adora's eyes soften, giving way to the anger and embracing the weight of the underlying sadness poisoning her words, '—I don't *have that*. I don't *have* a family. Catra was… she was *everything*, Glimmer. I

can’t—’ and this time when Adora’s voice gives way to a loud, wailing sob, Glimmer reaches out, pulling both herself and Adora closer together in—what she really hopes is—a warm and grounding hug.

Glimmer lets her friend cry into her shoulder. She holds Adora, trailing her hands up and down her back in the same way that Bow does for her when she’s feeling overwhelmed, hoping it will help at least a little bit. She knows that there isn’t really anything she can say to make this easier for Adora, to somehow lighten the burden of what Glimmer’s pretty certain she’s going through.

Adora’s letting go.

Ever since Glimmer met her at the training facility back on Etheria eight years ago, she’s known Adora’s deep and personal reason for going up into Space in the first place. She wanted to be as close as possible to Catra, because staying down on Etheria and living a life without her was just too unbearable. And now it doesn’t seem like Catra’s coming back. It’s been two whole years since her estimated return date passed them by, and three since the last recorded message was received from the Serenia 2. Even the techs in Dryl stopped sending their data transcripts, updates on Etheria and everything they’d missed.

Adora held on the longest but now, as her cries quiet down to ragged breathing, Glimmer knows she’s given up hope too.

‘I just wanted to hold her again,’ Adora whispers, and Glimmer can’t help the tear that escapes the corner of her eye at the words. It rolls down her cheek, landing in Adora’s hair. ‘I wanted to tell her how I felt about her, that I could never have lived the life she wanted me to without her there with me, because it was always her. She was *it* for me, you know?’

Glimmer nods as Adora pulls away, sitting back on the bed and leaving a small distance between them. ‘I know,’ she whispers, her voice quiet and full of emotion and hurt for her friend.

‘Back when we were together, before she moved to Dryl, I knew. I knew I could never love anyone else as much as I loved her. She was the light of my life, and I… I just miss her *so much* , I love her so much and now… now I have to *stop* . And it’s *killing me* that I have to let her go. What am I supposed to do now? I came up here to be closer to her, to wait for her, but she isn’t coming back and I don’t know what to do! It feels like there’s just this… *empty space* in me that will never be whole again and it *hurts so bad* . I don’t want to live in a world where Catra isn’t coming back home to me.’

And what is Glimmer supposed to say to that? How could Glimmer possibly say anything to make her friend feel better? Give her false hope? No. No, letting go will be good for her. Maybe she’ll even be able to move on eventually. ‘Me and Bow are here for you,’ Glimmer promises, her voice shaking, ‘we’re here, and we care about you. You’re welcome to stay up here, with us, and I can promise that we’ll never leave you alone. You’ll always have us, okay?’ Glimmer promises, resting her hand on Adora’s shoulder and squeezing lightly. Adora nods. ‘You’ll always have us.’

‘Thank you,’ Adora returns, leaning into the touch and sniffing away her tears.

‘Thank you.’

Catra, ?? years after the Serenia 2’s launch

They’re home.

Catra has no idea how long it's been, or what year it is on Etheria right now.

But that hardly matters, because they're *home* .

Catra and Scorpia are staring in awe out of the shuttle's reinforced windscreen at the familiar planet before them, all blues and greens, purples and pinks, as well as the twelve moons orbiting it. There's lights on them now, evidence of the colonisation they'd read about in the old reports from Etheria, the ones they stopped getting because of the broken communication dish, and they look a little more developed than what Catra was expecting.

What Catra was not expecting is the sheer size of the Arxia space station in orbit around Etheria. She'd read about it, of course—she even remembers her mothers talking about it—but the sight she's faced with differs greatly from what she remembers reading. Everything looks too advanced, too developed, too finished. None of it was finished when she was reading about it in the reports, and it was supposed to take years to complete all of it so… does that mean…?

An uneasy feeling settles into Catra's gut as she reluctantly entertains the possibility that they've been away a lot longer than they were supposed to be.

The ship's logs, without the data from Etheria to cross check, are unreliable. Entrapta says it would be impossible for them to guess how long they've been in Space without the data to double check. She told Catra that they could be back early, or they could be back late. She really doesn't know. Catra, just from looking at the planet below them, is fairly confident they're *not* early.

Speaking of Entrapta, Catra is fairly certain that she stayed out of her stasis pod a lot longer than she's letting on. Catra and Scorpia woke up four times on the way back, the fourth being the last one, and each time something would be different about the Serenia, more food missing, bits of circuitry and wires removed from one device and fixed to another part of the ship. Catra thinks

that Entrapta's been trying to fix the communications while her crewmates were asleep, but considering that she hasn't said anything yet there's no way that—

Catra happens to glance at Entrapta just as she pulls out a small, hand-made dish from under the control panel she's sitting next to, holding it up toward Etheria and then, with her other hand, flicking switches on the communications panel, her smile growing wider as it lights up like a Christmas tree.

'Entrapta,' Catra starts, because please let this not be a fluke, 'what are you—'

'We're within range!' Entrapta squeaks, turning to face Scorpia and Catra where they're still floating with their faces practically pressed against the glass.

'Entrapta, explain, what do you mean *in range* ?' Catra's fairly sure she knows what Entrapta's done, but as her heart begins thumping harder and harder in her chest she knows she *needs* to hear the technician *say it* .

'I'm so glad you asked!' Entrapta beams, unbuckling herself from her seat and floating forward to join her stunned crewmates, both watching her with wide eyes, at the front of the bridge. She sets the dish on top of the main console, a mess of wires trailing behind it back to the communication controls, and then turns to pull herself back over to the comms controls. 'During our return journey, I was able to build what I approximated to be an almost exact replica of the original communications dish from other tech within the ship!' ('Which bits of tech?' Scorpia whispers to Catra, but Catra waves her off, too focused on what Entrapta's saying to care about the *how* .) 'But I couldn't get it to work over long-range like the original, so I waited until now to test its short-range capabilities! Which…' Entrapta fiddles with a few more controls, flicking switches and buttons on the console as Catra and Scorpia position themselves behind her, until—

‘…lo? Hel…lo? This…Arxia Spaceport…identify yourself. I repeat, this is Arxia Spaceport. Please identify yourself. Over.’

A *voice* . Crackly at first, but it becomes more clear as Entrapta fiddles with the controls. A voice. A voice! A *real person* !

‘The test is a resounding success!’ Entrapta shouts, squealing excitedly in her chair. ‘I wonder if we’ve received any new messages since the communications have been restored—’

‘I’ll check!’ Catra erupts, before she really has a chance to think through what she’s saying or doing. All she knows is that her heart is thumping in her chest, thundering in her ears, as she passes through the ship to where their equipment is set up for them to receive and view messages.

Sure enough, there’s hundreds of unread data samples and messages waiting for her. She scrolls through them, scanning through missives of news and happenings from across Etheria, updates on the Arxia project, the moon colonisation. Catra sees at least twenty or thirty messages from her mothers alone, nevermind the others for her crewmates, but… one stands out to her.

One.

—----------

Message Received: Subject: *Hey Catra* . Sender: *Adora Grayskull* . Attachment: {video_file21}

—----------

It's from *Adora* . Adora sent Catra a message. Suddenly, nothing else matters. Catra doesn't care whether or not she deserves this, if Adora doesn't love her anymore and it's just a "hope you're okay" message. She doesn't care if there's another woman in this video with Adora. She has to watch it.

With shaking hands and tears already threatening to spill over, Catra clicks on the attached video.

It starts with a quick flash of light followed by darkness and some muffled cursing as whatever it is that's recording falls forwards, obscuring the camera. Then Adora's face is in view as she repositions the camera again before sitting back on what looks like a bed in a rather dismal looking room.

"Hey, Catra. Adora here! Well, you know that. Obviously. Uhm," in the video, Adora chuckles, rubbing at the back of her neck. Catra can't help but smile.

She hasn't seen Adora since she broke up with her. Hasn't heard her voice. Yet, here she is, just how Catra remembers her.

"It's been seven years since you left. You're supposed to arrive next year, so, this is me just… I guess I wanted to let you know what's happening. What I've been doing. How I feel…"

Catra frowns. Adora's nervous, she looks like she's about to cry. It makes Catra anxious, a ball of worry building in her gut.

"I'm just– I'm just gonna say it," Adora takes a deep breath, and, *"I broke my promise to you! I couldn't do it! I couldn't live my life without you here, Catra, because you were—* are *—everything to me! I love you so much, and I miss you so much, and for the past seven years all I've been thinking about is when you'd come back to me. I know you said not to wait, but I couldn't handle being down on Etheria while you were up here, gods-knows-where, so I followed you. At least, as far as I could. I work on the Arxia station as a Physical Therapist now. I make sure everyone stays in shape while they're on the station and, yeah,* 'all that healthy shit'

as you used to call it. I'm happy. I've got friends. I have a life. But, it isn't complete without you here. I know this is a lot to spring on you but, Catra, if you still love me when you see this, please respond. Please tell me if you still love me, too. If you don't, then, I'll just go. But if you do… I want you back, Cat. I need you." Adora wipes at her face, brushing away tears and she lurches forward to grab whatever it is that's recording her and looks down into the camera. She looks so sad as she whispers, *"See you soon. Hopefully. I love you."* And the video cuts to black.

Catra's shaking, barely containing her emotions as she desperately checks the timestamp from when the message was sent vs. when it was received…

The message is *old* . Very old. Catra almost bursts into tears when she sees the received date— *the current date* —and compares it to when the video was sent. According to this, Catra's been gone for *twelve years* , and this message was sent five years ago. *Five years ago.* That would have been around a year before she was supposed to be back. Why would Adora send her a message before she got back? Catra never sent Adora anything because she thought, well, that Adora would have *moved on* . Hated her, maybe. That she definitely wouldn't want to hear from the ex who left her to go flying around the galaxy for eight years. Catra gave her a way out and the idiot *didn't take it* .

Adora – Sweet, amazing, *Adora* —

'Of course I still love you, dummy,' Catra whispers to no-one, five years too late, before she folds in on herself and cries, and cries, and cries.

———————

Catra feels numb.

She should be happier, more excited, buzzing around the shuttle like Entapta and Scorpia. Her crewmates have also seen their messages, even sent some back in their unbridled joy. Catra, however, just feels like she's lost the one thing that truly matters to her.

Five years is a long time. Adora will be long gone by now, probably back down on Etheria, doing whatever it is she found to help her forget. Five years is plenty of time for Adora to have gotten over Catra, to have moved on properly this time, to meet someone new. After five years of silence and Catra not being here, there's no way Adora waited for her. Catra can't help but think of the what ifs…

What if Catra had received that message? Returned to Etheria on time? Would they be together now? Happy? Catra drowns in these thoughts, mourning a life she never got to live.

So, as the escort ships approach the Serenia 2, pulling them toward the Arxia Spaceport with something called a tractor beam that Entrapta seems very interested in (she also seems to think her lab partner had something to do with that particular innovation), Catra sits alone, and tries not to think at all.

There aren't any parades to greet them, and they're certainly not welcomed as heroes.

It becomes clear pretty quickly that most of the people on Arxia have forgotten about them, the Serenia 2, and their mission. They're treated like imposters, aliens, and criminals. Apparently, Arxia doesn't intercept any traffic from outside the system, like, *at all* , so they're in a tizzy about the Serenia's appearance and don't really seem to know what to do with them. The crew are separated. Catra's taken to an interrogation room where, after a

doctor checks her over to make sure she isn't carrying a space-illness or something, she's asked question after inane question about who she is and where she came from.

Catra gives up after a while, because they *aren't listening* , and refuses to answer any further questions until she speaks to whoever's in charge. That shuts them up, her interrogators glancing at one another before leaving the room entirely.

She's left alone for maybe ten minutes, during which Catra has counted most of the dents in the table she's cuffed to, until a loud, shrill voice pierces the silence from outside the room. Someone isn't happy, and Catra smiles at the thought of those uptight pricks who thought they were all big and scary getting shouted by—as the door to her interrogation room slams open, Catra gets a good look at her—a fairly short, suited woman with bright pink hair and an angry face, that quickly softens as her eyes slowly take in Catra.

'What did you say your name was?' The sparkly one asks.

'I didn't,' Catra replies, smirking.

'Tell me. *Please* .'

And maybe it's the sincerity behind her eyes that makes Catra trust her, but after a small staredown she relents, and sighs, 'Catra. My name's Catra.'

The woman lurches forward immediately, uncuffing Catra and grabbing at her hand with frightening speed. 'Come with me,' she says, pulling Catra from the room, 'don't resist. Co-operate and I promise this will be worth your time.'

Catra rolls her eyes, nothing this sparkly boss-lady could possibly have to show her could be worth her time, but whatever. The looks on Catra's interrogators' faces as she'd led from the room make the whole thing worth it anyway.

Eventually, Catra's led to what looks like some kind of monorail and is all but thrown into the nearest car, quickly followed by the sparkle tornado, just as the doors hiss closed and the transport begins moving along the rail.

'Bow,' the woman speaks, and Catra thinks she could be talking to her until she spots the earpiece, 'where is she?—It's important—I'll tell you soon, will you *just* —Okay, thank you, Bow. I love you.'

Catra fights down the urge to tease this woman about who she could've been talking to and why their name is Bow, and instead asks, 'Will you at least tell me your name? And where are you taking me?'

She stares Catra down for a moment—stares up? It's unclear. Catra feels observed but the woman is shorter than her, so she can't really decide whether or not she feels intimidated—until she huffs and crosses her arms over her chest. 'I'm Glimmer. I'm Director of the Arxia Spaceport.'

Catra blinks, processing both the *name* and the title. 'And that means…'

'I run the place. Think of me as Queen, if that makes it easier.'

Catra scoffs, but she can't help but agree that Glitter (no way is actually using this person's real name, *ever*) does have an air of royalty about her. 'Whatever you say, your *Majesty* ,' Catra drawls, sealing the deal with a wink, and eating up the way Glimmer's cheeks blaze a fiery red.

Whatever Glimmer was going to say in retort is cut short, however, as the monorail gently comes to a stop and the doors slide open behind her. She squeaks, caught off guard by their apparent arrival at their destination, and reaches forward to grab Catra's wrist, yanking her off and out into a wide open space that doesn't look too dissimilar to a—

'Is this a shopping mall?!' Catra balks, glancing around her as much as she can as she's pulled forward by this very over-eager,

glitter-ridden short person.

‘Kind of?’ Glimmer replies, Catra only just able to hear her over the general hubbub of activity. ‘Capitalism’s a big hit in Space, apparently. Bow used to say Arxia is just like an airport, if you remember those, all security and shops and people passing through.’

Catra’s a bit too stunned by the fact that all of this is on a man-made thing in Space—plus, there’s *gravity?* What the fuck? Why didn’t the Serenia have gravity?—so she barely registers when Glimmer stops, sighing in relief.

‘Good, she’s still here.’

‘Who’s here?’ Catra asks, following Glimmer’s line of sight to—

To—

Adora?

It can’t be.

There’s no actual way that Adora is just sitting there, in the window of some cross between a cafe and a diner, on a space station in Space. It’s not real– It can’t be– But Glimmer is just smiling at Catra sadly, and Catra finds that she wants to scream.

Fuck . Catra has to fight against her face to stop it from contorting into something ugly as too many emotions wash over her at once. Her body feels like it wants to curl up right here and now, to cry and sob and scream into the floor because this *can’t* be real. She can’t be, just, sitting there? Right? She’s— She’s *beautiful.*

Glimmer is just staring at her, and Catra isn't really sure what to make of that as her mind and body stutter and restart a few times in quick succession. It’s like this person *knows* her and, *fuck* , she led Catra to *Adora — straight to her* —of course this person knows who she is.

‘Go to her,’ are the words that leave Sparkles’ mouth, and Catra just fucking *hugs her.* Partly because she doesn’t know what else to do, and partly because she knows this isn’t the last time they’ll see one another.

‘Thank you,’ she hisses into the woman’s shoulder as a hand awkwardly pats her back. *‘Thank you. ’*

Leaving Glimmer behind, looking dazed after the sudden hug and with what Catra’s pretty sure is glitter stuck to her cheek, she practically sprints over to the entrance of the little diner. When she gets to the door, however, and it opens of its own accord, she pauses. Tears bite at her eyes, blinding her while leaving dark lines in the short, fine fur on her cheeks.

She looks older, more mature. Catra has to take a minute to process that, yes, Adora is older. *12 years* older, now, in fact. Catra always knew that Adora would end up being older than her by the time she returned, but not this much, 8 years at least.

Adora’s looking at her. Fuck. Catra hurries her brain to think of something to do, but it’s not working, she’s rooted to the spot and can’t find the will to step forward and—

Someone pushes past her, barging their way into the diner and suddenly Catra’s moving forward and she finds that she can’t stop. Her eyes are fixed on Adora’s and Adora’s are fixed on hers.

As she looks into those oceans of beautiful blue, Catra knows in an instant that if Adora will have her back, love her back, Catra will jump into her arms in an instant. But Adora’s brows furrow in, *what is that?* Confusion? Disbelief? Longing? Adora’s face seems to suggest that Catra is not a welcome sight, and it takes everything within her to keep her feet moving forward, to not turn and *run* as panic threatens to overtake her. She’s feeling *so much* at once and it feels too much but she *has to do this* .

Catra runs through the time again in her head. The Serenia’s voyage was eight years relative to her crew, Catra’s body only

aged by four because of the stasis pods, but to her mind it's only been nearly two years total.

Adora's been here, waiting, for *twelve years.*

It doesn't compare.

Fuck, it doesn't compare!

Of course Adora isn't happy to see her! Catra broke up with her, left on some stupid, pointless voyage through Space, and couldn't even get back on time. There's absolutely no way that Adora will want her again and Catra stops a few strides away from the table. Her fists clench at her sides, her claws digging into the palms of her hands as she tries and fails to hold back a sob, tears falling down her face without her permission, betraying her inner turmoil. She shuts her eyes tight as Adora stands, fully expecting her to walk past, to leave Catra behind again just as Catra did to her. Gods knows she deserves it. Adora should leave her behind. Adora shouldn't still love her. Catra's an idiot to think anything else could possibly—

Warm.

Soft.

Safe.

Catra purrs for the first time in years as a familiar scent clouds her senses, as a familiar warmth surrounds her, as familiar arms hold her tight like she isn't real, like she might float away. Catra's arms come up too, wrapping around Adora's frame and digging in. Catra can feel Adora crying, can feel the way she's being held, and she relaxes. She allows a feeling of blissful contentment to wash over her, ground her, reassure her.

She allows her love to bloom within her again, and she smiles.

'Hey, Adora… I'm home.'

End Notes

;-;

The question I kept asking myself while writing this was: what happened to the Serenia 1?
I believe that the Serenia 2 *is* the Serenia 1, but Entrapta tinkered with it so much that it became a completely different ship, no longer matching the original blueprints, so they had to award it with a new designation while frantically trying to keep track of everything that Entrapta was changing.

Also, if you're curious about the ash on the last visited planet, it was floating because it's *much lighter* than ash would be on Etheria, it's composed differently as Entrapta will later find out when she goes through the samples, so it is falling, just *really slowly*, the fact that so much of it managed to settle hints at just how dead the planet is. Nothing's moved on it for *a very long time*. Think dinosaur-level extinction event, but the planet never recovers.

Part 2 will be the epilogue, based around Emilee's extra fifth drawing. See you then!

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